

CROCODILES



SUBMERGED BELOW water, crocodiles lie in wait ready to attack almost any animal that strays too close. Crocodiles belong to the group of reptiles, called the crocodylians, which has remained largely unchanged for more than 140 million years. This group contains crocodiles, alligators, caimans, and gharials which are all very similar apart from small differences, such as snout shape and arrangement of teeth. All are effective freshwater predators and are well adapted to a semi-aquatic way of life.

Eyes

A crocodile's eyes protrude above its snout providing 25° overlapping vision to judge distance. A third eyelid slides across from the side to allow underwater vision. Special pupils allow more light to reach the retina in low light levels and protect the retina from bright light. The retina itself has a layer of night-seeing cells that glow red in torchlight.



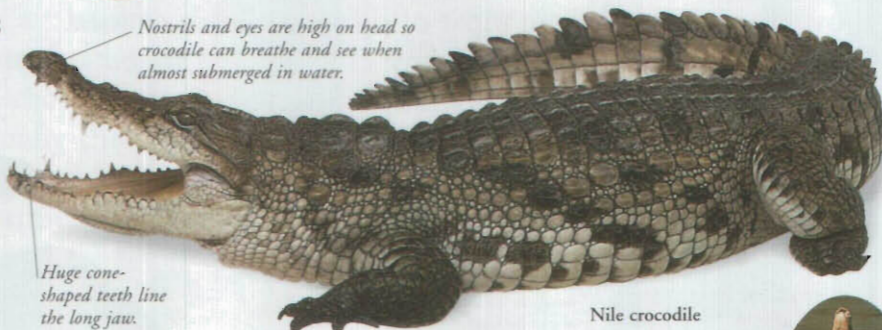
Third eyelid moves across from side.



Transparent eyelid converts eye for underwater vision.

Nostrils and eyes are high on head so crocodile can breathe and see when almost submerged in water.

Huge cone-shaped teeth line the long jaw.



Nile crocodile

Snout shape

Alligators and caimans have broad, rounded snouts, while gharials have very narrow snouts. Crocodiles have broad or narrow snouts. They also have an externally visible fourth tooth. This distinguishes them from alligators in which this tooth is concealed.



Caiman



Alligator



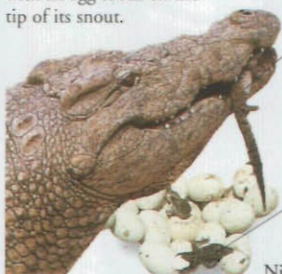
Crocodile



Gharial

Breeding

Loud bellowing precedes mating under water. One month later females lay up to 90 leathery-shelled eggs that they incubate for 2–3 months in nests. Some species lay eggs in several locations to avoid total loss by flooding or predation. High temperatures during incubation result in more males than females. A hatchling calls its mother with squeaks and breaks out of the eggshell by "pipping" with an egg tooth on the tip of its snout.



Mother carries young to a crèche where she will guard them until they become independent.

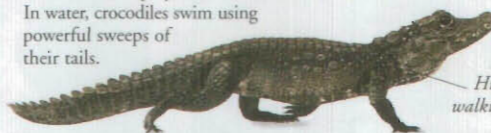
Baby crocodile pushing itself out of its egg.

Nile crocodile with eggs

Movement

On land crocodiles may slide along on their bellies, scooting with their feet. Sometimes they adopt the "high walk" and raise their bodies fully off the ground. The "gallop" is when crocodiles run with their tails in the air, usually when being chased. The "tail walk" is used to snatch prey from branches above the water.

In water, crocodiles swim using powerful sweeps of their tails.



Dwarf crocodile



Tail walking involves pushing the body up using the tail.

Feeding

After lying hidden for hours, a crocodile suddenly seizes prey from riverbanks and drags it below water until it drowns. Crocodiles cannot chew, so prey is dismembered by shaking and spinning. The whole animal is eaten. Strong juices and pebbles in the stomach help break down the food.

Topi

The jaws close with tremendous force, splintering bone and crushing tissue.



Alligators

There are two true alligators. The American alligator from south-east United States is up to 5.5 m (18 ft) long. It is the only crocodylian that is not endangered. The Chinese alligator from the Yangtze River, eastern China, is smaller at up to 2 m (7 ft). Alligators are subtropical, and are more widely distributed than other crocodylians.



American alligator

Regular-sized scales

Thick muscular tail

Caimans

Caimans are South American alligators. There are six species ranging from the 1.5 m (5 ft) long dwarf caiman that lives in forest creeks to the 4.5 m (15 ft) long black caiman of larger rivers. The spectacled caiman has ridges around the eyes resembling spectacle frames.

Spectacled caiman



Stocky body

Gharials

There are two species of gharial, which have long narrow snouts. The Ganges gharial lives in India, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Nepal, and Burma. It reaches 7 m (23 ft) in length. Some males have a bulbous swelling on the end of their snout. The other species, the tomistoma, lives in Indonesia and Malaysia. It reaches a length of 4.7 m (15.5 ft).

Widely spaced teeth line the forcep-like jaw

Ganges gharial



NILE CROCODILE

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Crocodylus niloticus*

ORDER Crocodylia

FAMILY Crocodylidae

DISTRIBUTION Africa south of the Sahara, excluding the Kalahari; Madagascar. Now largely exterminated from the River Nile in Egypt

HABITAT River systems, lakes, marshes, estuaries, and mangrove habitats. Also able to swim out to sea

DIET Fish, frogs, reptiles, wading birds, and mammals up to the size of water buffalo. Humans are also sometimes victims

SIZE Length: 6 m (20 ft)

LIFESPAN 25–100 years

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